

▲ REVISION 1 · ISSUED FOR CONSTRUCTION

IN RESPONSE TO THE DRAWING SET TITLED "MIAMI →
JACKSONVILLE, PARCE", 13 SHEETS, DATED 4
SEPTEMBER 2026

~~MIAMI → JACKSONVILLE~~ MIAMI → TAMPA BAY

Diego. Naty. That is a genuinely good deck. I read all
thirteen slides twice. It is right about almost everything, and
it still points you at the wrong city.

Here is the same argument with the third option left in.

PROJECT

Getting you out of
Miami

SHEETS

17, in reply to 13

PREPARED BY

The friends who
already lived in
Jacksonville

ISSUED

5 September 2026

AGREED. LEAVE MIAMI.

This is not a defense of Miami. I am not going to tell you the housing math is fine, because it is not fine.

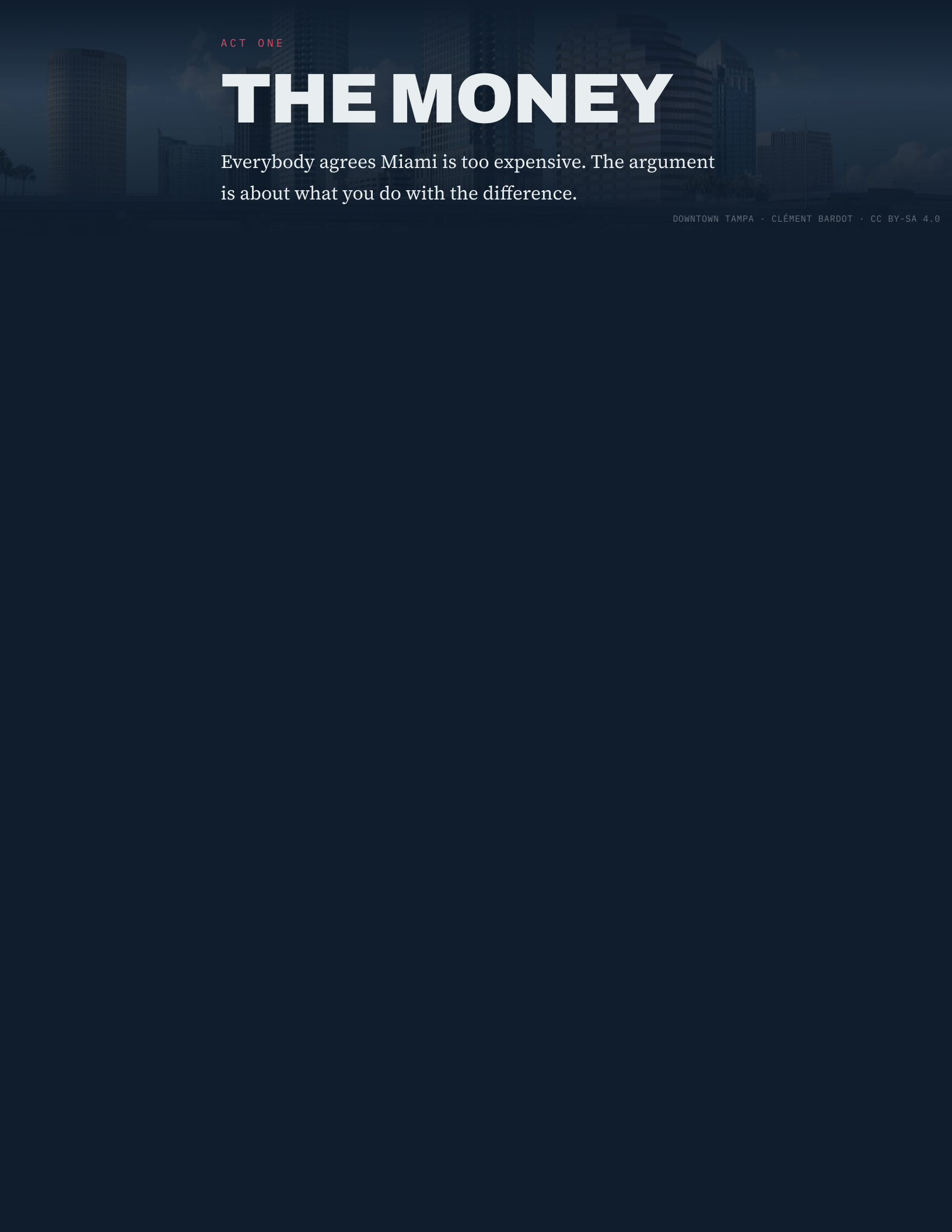
JACKSONVILLE DECK • SLIDE 02

“Trade some Miami intensity for space, optionality and family bandwidth.”

Correct. Every word. A thirty-seven-year-old architect with a wife and a five-year-old should not be handing that much of his income to a landlord or a lender so that he can be near a nightclub he has not been inside since 2019.

So we agree on the problem, and we agree on roughly ninety percent of that deck. What follows is the other ten percent, and the other ten percent is the whole move.

It compares two cities. Florida has more than two cities.



ACT ONE

THE MONEY

Everybody agrees Miami is too expensive. The argument is about what you do with the difference.

DOWNTOWN TAMPA · CLÉMENT BARDOT · CC BY-SA 4.0

SAME SOURCE. SAME DAY. ONE MORE CITY.

Slide 4 cites Livingcost.org, updated 21 June 2026, for the cost of raising a family. I opened the identical page. I changed one city in the URL.

Estimated monthly cost, family of four

LIVINGCOST.ORG · UPDATED 21 JUNE 2026 · THE DECK'S OWN
SOURCE, ITS OWN DATE

MIAMI TAMPA JACKSONVILLE



Miami → Jacksonville saves **\$2,220** a month. Miami → Tampa
saves **\$1,567** a month.

SCALE RUNS 0 TO \$7,364. ALL THREE FIGURES FROM THE SAME COMPARISON TOOL ON THE SAME UPDATE DATE. [3]

70.6%

OF THE SAVINGS THE
JACKSONVILLE DECK PROMISED,
KEPT — WITHOUT MOVING SIX
HOURS FARTHER FROM MIAMI

That is the entire rebuttal in one number. The deck sells an escape from Miami prices. Tampa delivers seven-tenths of that escape. The remaining three-tenths is what the rest of these sheets is about, and I am going to price it honestly.

Jacksonville is cheaper than Tampa by \$653 a month. I am not going to pretend otherwise. I am going to tell you what that \$653 is buying.

\$653

MORE PER MONTH

IN TAMPA

+\$518

HIGHER MEDIAN

AFTER-TAX PAY IN TAMPA

\$135

ACTUAL MONTHLY GAP

AFTER THE RAISE

Median after-tax salary is \$3,945 in Jacksonville and \$4,463 in Tampa. ^[3]

Same source. Roughly eighty percent of the cost difference is absorbed by the fact that Tampa pays people more.

IT PICKED THE EASIEST COMPARISON IN FLORIDA.

Slide 3 puts Jacksonville next to Miami and lets a \$339,830 gap do the persuading. It is a real gap, honestly sourced. It is also the one matchup no Florida city can lose.

Here is what happens when you put Jacksonville next to the places I am actually proposing. Same source for all five, so nobody gets to pick a favorable methodology.

Typical home value

ZILLOW HOME VALUE INDEX · 2026 · ONE SOURCE, FIVE PLACES

■ WHAT YOU'RE LEAVING ■ TAMPA BAY ■ JACKSONVILLE



Plant City minus Jacksonville: **\$47,855**. Miami minus Plant City: **\$238,099**.

SCALE RUNS 0 TO \$581,864. ZILLOW HOME VALUE INDEX, A SMOOTHED TYPICAL-VALUE MEASURE, CHOSEN BECAUSE IT IS PUBLISHED FOR SMALL CITIES LIKE PLANT CITY WHERE MEDIAN-SALE FIGURES GET THIN. ^[4]

Jacksonville wins this chart. It wins it by \$47,855, which at current rates is a couple hundred dollars a month on a note.

Against Miami that gap looks like the difference between two lives. Against Plant City it is the difference between two kitchens.

WHAT YOU ARE ACTUALLY SHOPPING FOR

You have said you want a bigger house with a garage, and that is the whole point of leaving Miami. In Riverview, Plant City, Wesley Chapel and the Brandon corridor, a two-car garage is not an upgrade, it is what the house comes with. That is true in Jacksonville too. The difference is not what the house has. It is what is around it.

SO WHAT DOES \$653 A MONTH GET YOU?

Every sheet from here is priced against that number. If Jacksonville's discount is worth more than what follows, take it. It is a real city and that was a real argument.

But you should see the other side of the ledger before you sign anything, and the Jacksonville deck never had reason to put it there. This is that list.

Ninety minutes closer to your family, each way

1.8× the school district she works with

A dinosaur park in the zip code

Disney 45 minutes closer

A nonstop to Bogotá

A house with a garage

An ocean you can get in during February

573,299 people, in our town, every March

Named cranes instead of a budget line

A third of the homicides

Us, twenty minutes away

JACKSONVILLE IS GROWING FASTER. HERE IS WHY THAT STILL LOSES.

You asked the right question, which is not what either place costs this year. It is what you are holding in twenty years, when the kid is twenty-five and you are deciding whether you still have to work.

So let me give Jacksonville its best sheet first, because it has one and nobody put it in the deck. Lightcast projected the Jacksonville metro to grow eleven percent between 2023 and 2028, faster than any other major Florida metro, faster than the state, and faster than the country. ^[19] That is a genuinely good number and it is the strongest long-run argument anyone could have made.

It is also a percentage of a smaller base, and you cannot spend a percentage.

Three things actually decide how this looks in 2046.

ONE. WHAT THE HOUSEHOLD EARNS

Median household income

2024 · COUNTY LEVEL · SAME SOURCE, SAME YEAR



SCALE RUNS 0 TO \$79,540. HILLSBOROUGH SITS 6.7% ABOVE THE FLORIDA MEDIAN; DUVAL SITS 4.4% BELOW IT. ^[18]

\$165,260

THE INCOME GAP ALONE, OVER
TWENTY YEARS, BEFORE A SINGLE
RAISE OR A CENT OF INTEREST

That is arithmetic, not a forecast: \$8,263 a year, held flat, twenty times. Any real version of it is larger, because raises compound and that gap is a percentage too.

TWO. THE BASE IT COMPOUNDS ON

The eight-county Tampa Bay region is projected to go from 5,087,431 people to 6,507,900 by 2050, adding roughly 1.42 million. Hillsborough alone is projected to reach 1,981,900 and to take one of every three of those new residents. ^[19]

Jacksonville grows at a higher rate. Tampa Bay adds more people, more households and more buyers, which is what actually sets the price of the house you eventually sell.

THREE. WHAT THE COUNTY TAKES

Duval's total millage runs about 17.86. Hillsborough's runs about 15.73.

^[20] Jacksonville taxes each dollar of assessed value harder than we do.

The median bill here is larger, \$3,758 against \$2,820, and that is only because the houses are worth more, which is the entire reason a person buys one.

AND THE RETIREMENT PART, HONESTLY

Nearly everything that makes Florida good to retire in is identical in both cities. No state income tax. No estate tax. The homestead exemption. The Save Our Homes three percent assessment cap, and the portability that lets you carry that cap to any other county in the state. On tax treatment this is a wash, and anybody who tells you otherwise is selling something.

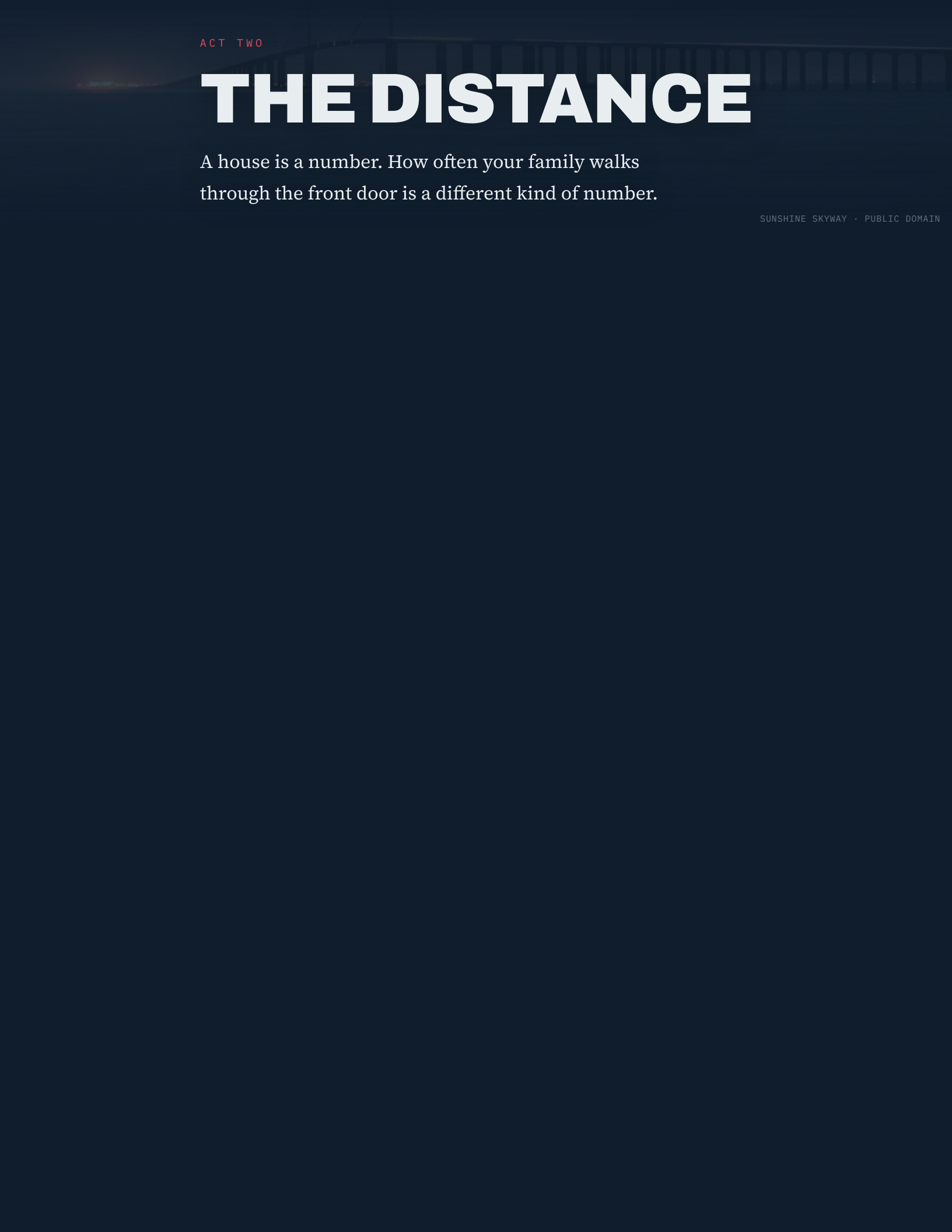
What differs is what you retire holding, and what you retire beside.

JACKSONVILLE WINS THE HOSPITAL.

Mayo Clinic Florida is in Jacksonville, and in the 2026–27 rankings it joined the Honor Roll of the twenty best hospitals in the United States, the first Florida hospital to get there. If you are optimising for the single best place in the state to grow old next to, that is the answer and I am not going to argue with it. ^[21]

Tampa's reply is a bench rather than a peak. Tampa General is the top-ranked hospital in the Tampa–St. Petersburg region, Moffitt is second in Florida for cancer and a National Cancer Institute designated comprehensive centre, and USF Health sits behind both. ^[21] One extraordinary hospital against three very good ones is a real trade and reasonable people land differently on it.

And when you are seventy and want to see your grandchildren, Tampa is still the airport with the nonstop and the four-hour drive.



ACT TWO

THE DISTANCE

A house is a number. How often your family walks
through the front door is a different kind of number.

SUNSHINE SKYWAY · PUBLIC DOMAIN

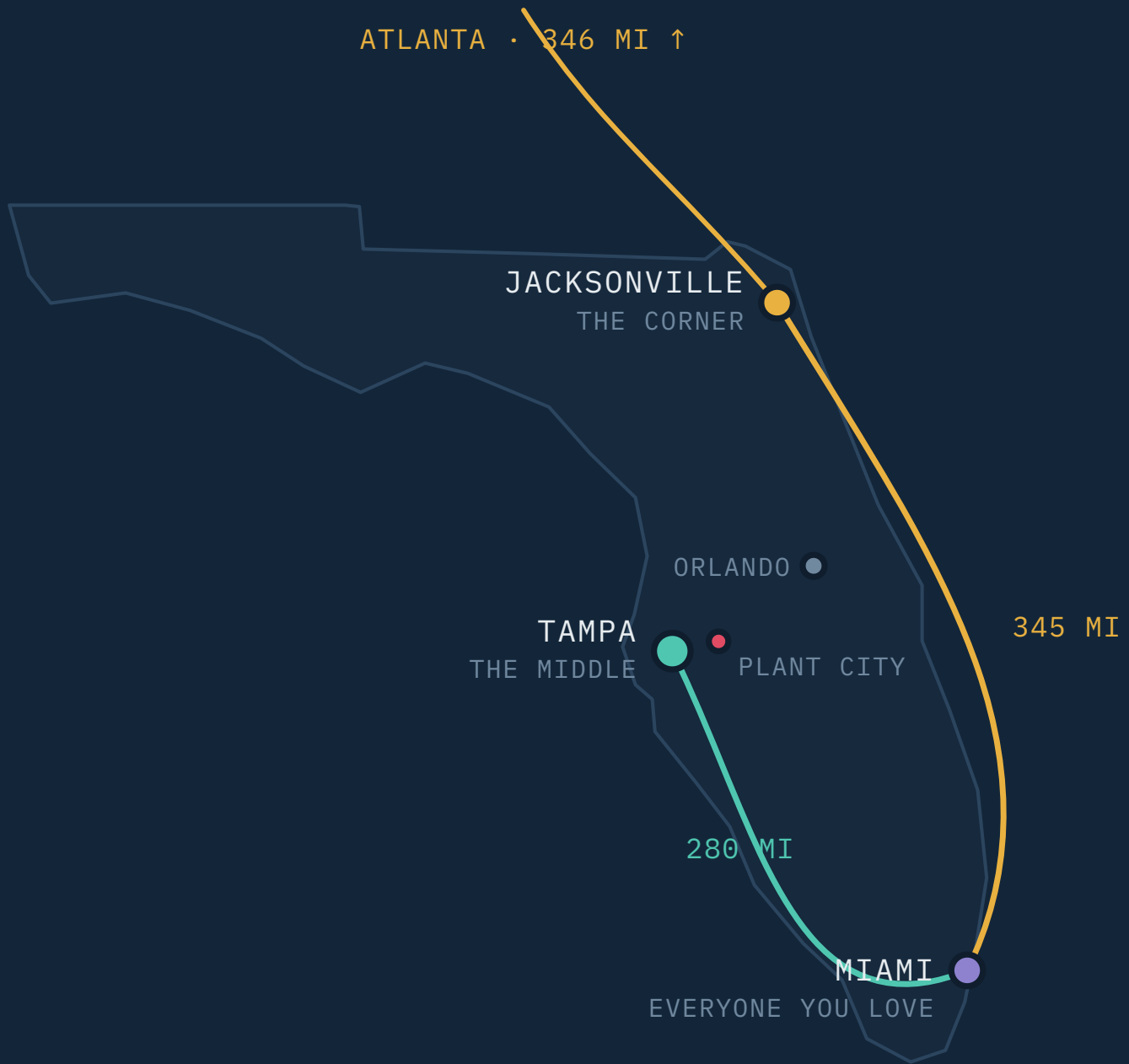
FROM JACKSONVILLE, ATLANTA IS CLOSER THAN YOUR FAMILY.

Not almost. Closer by a mile. Slide 10 sells Jacksonville as a launchpad and lists St. Augustine, Amelia Island, Orlando and Savannah. Notice which city is not on that list.

This is the sheet that matters most, because your whole family is in one city and neither of these moves puts you in it. The only question is how far away you agree to be.

Where each city actually sits

ROAD MILES • TAMPA IS THE MIDDLE OF THE STATE, JACKSONVILLE
IS A CORNER OF IT



DISTANCES ARE ROAD MILES, NOT STRAIGHT-LINE. THE ATLANTA LINE RUNS OFF THE TOP OF THE STATE ON PURPOSE. ^[7]

Driving distance to the people you are leaving behind

ROAD MILES, MIAMI UNLESS NOTED

Jax → Atlanta	346 mi
Jax → Miami	345 mi
Tampa → Miami	280 mi ≈3h 55m

SCALE RUNS 0 TO 346 MILES. DRIVING DISTANCE, NOT STRAIGHT-LINE. ^[7]

Move to Jacksonville and Georgia sits as close to you as everyone you are leaving in Miami. That is not a joke at anyone's expense. It is a coincidence of geography that happens to be perfect.

Tampa is a Saturday-morning drive. Leave after breakfast, be there for lunch, and your kid falls asleep in the car on the way home that night. Jacksonville is five to six hours each way, which quietly turns every visit into a three-day commitment, and turns most of them into no visit at all.

^[7]

Sixty-five miles does not sound like a relationship. Ninety minutes each way, forty weekends a year, for the next twenty years, is a relationship.

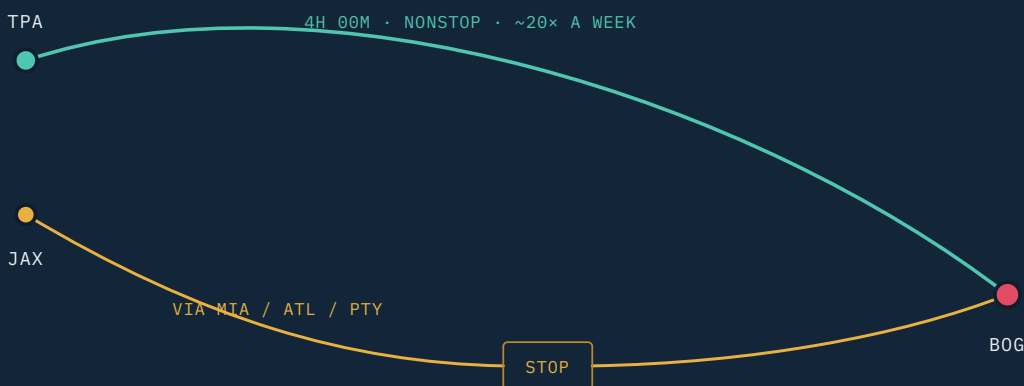
And the rest of the state opens up on top of it. Orlando in about ninety minutes, Sarasota in under an hour, Fort Myers in two. ^[7]

TAMPA FLIES TO BOGOTÁ. JACKSONVILLE DOESN'T.

Your family is in Miami, so this one is a bonus rather than the argument. It is still the single cleanest fact in this document. Avianca has flown Tampa to Bogotá nonstop since March 2025. It went daily that October. It now runs about twenty flights a week.

Getting to Bogotá

THE SAME TRIP, FROM TWO FLORIDA AIRPORTS



AVIANCA HAS FLOWN TAMPA TO BOGOTÁ NONSTOP SINCE MARCH 2025. JACKSONVILLE HAS NO SCHEDULED NONSTOP TO SOUTH AMERICA. ^[5]

FROM TAMPA

TPA ————— **BOG**

4h 00m

Nonstop, Avianca, A320neo. Roughly 20 departures a week. TPA's first scheduled nonstop to South America in nearly fifty years. ^[5]

FROM JACKSONVILLE

JAX ————— **MIA / ATL / PTY** ————— **BOG**

No such flight

JAX has two international nonstops: San Juan, which is a US territory, and Toronto, which is seasonal. Zero to South America. ^[6]

And it is not a gap anyone is racing to close. Jacksonville's airport authority commissioned a study on which nonstop international routes to chase next. The shortlist came back Dublin, Frankfurt, London, Paris, Reykjavík. ^[6]

Not one South American city. Jacksonville is not planning to fly to your family. It is planning to fly to Iceland.

Nobody moves cities over a flight route. But your kid is five, and at some point you are going to want him to know where he is from, and the difference between a four-hour nonstop and a connection through Atlanta is the difference between going every couple of years and going once.

“ENOUGH COLOMBIAN FOOD TO SURVIVE.”

Survive. That is slide 12’s own word, in the list of what you are really buying. An honest word, and I want the record to show that the ceiling being offered here is *survival*.

JACKSONVILLE DECK · SLIDE 08

“Miami has the deeper Colombian ecosystem. Jax gives you enough connection while buying back space, cost and pace.”

It names three. Delicias Colombianas, Antojitos, Salento. That is an honest list, and it is also close to the complete list, which is the problem.

Tampa Bay and greater Orlando together hold roughly 85,000 Colombians, described in the migration literature as the second-largest concentration in the United States after Miami. Florida holds about thirty percent of the entire Colombian diaspora, and the three named centers are Miami–Fort Lauderdale, Orlando–Kissimmee, and Tampa Bay.^[8]

Jacksonville appears on none of those lists.

WITHIN THIRTY MINUTES OF OUR HOUSE

Los 3 Parces · Brandon

Ricopan Bakehouse · Brandon

Ricopan Bakehouse · Riverview

Ricopan Bakehouse · Tampa

Aleida’s Kitchen · Brandon

La Pequeña Colombia · Brandon

Rappi Colombian Food · Brandon

Cali Aji · Riverview

Mi Carreta · Tampa

El Cafetal · Tampa

El Fogón Colombiano · Tampa

Monserate · Tampa

Restaurante La Hacienda · Tampa

Antojitos Latin Cravings · Tampa

Santa Ana’s Bakery · Town ‘n Country

Fifteen, and I stopped writing, not because I ran out.

Los 3 Parces

IS A REAL COLOMBIAN RESTAURANT
IN BRANDON, FLORIDA, ABOUT
TWENTY MINUTES FROM OUR FRONT
DOOR

Diego. The word *parce* is on the cover of that deck. There is a restaurant named after it twenty minutes from here. The pitch is quoting our neighborhood to sell you a different one.

THAT OCEAN IS 58 DEGREES IN FEBRUARY.

Slide 9 is titled “The ocean didn’t stay in Miami,” which is true, and then offers “surf-and-bike coastal living,” which is the phrase you reach for when the water is cold.

Average water temperature, February

DEGREES FAHRENHEIT · THE MONTH THAT DECIDES WHETHER A BEACH IS A BEACH

Clearwater, Gulf

63.0°F

Jax Beach, Atlantic

58.8°F

SCALE RUNS 0 TO 63°F. AT THE SAME LATITUDE THE GULF RUNS ROUGHLY 3 TO 5 DEGREES WARMER THAN THE ATLANTIC THROUGH THE WINTER. [9]



Four degrees does not sound like an argument until you are the parent standing in it. But temperature is the smaller half of this.

The Gulf here is shallow, flat and slow. A five-year-old can walk out a long way and the water stays at his chest. North Florida’s Atlantic has surf, and shore break, and rip currents, which is genuinely wonderful if you are

twenty-two with a board and genuinely tiring if you are the one watching
a kindergartener in it.

That is a beach for the man you were. This is a beach for the man with a five-year-old.

WHAT A SATURDAY ACTUALLY LOOKS LIKE.

Slide 7 promised a backyard, beach days, parks and weekend range. All four are true of Jacksonville and all four are true here, so that slide does not actually decide anything. These two things do.

FIRST, THE SCHOOLS, AND THIS ONE SPLITS

	HILLSBOROUGH	DUVAL - JAX
District grade, Florida DOE	A	B
Graduation rate, class of 2025	90.9%	94.3%
Students enrolled	226,000	128,000

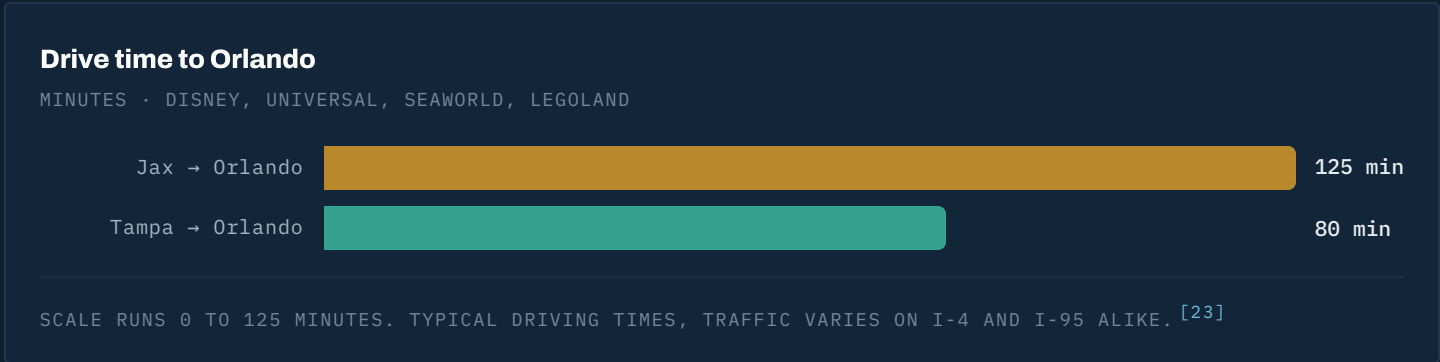
Hillsborough earned an A from the state in 2026, its first in more than a decade. Duval holds a B. But Duval graduates more of its kids than we do, 94.3% against our 90.9%, against a Florida average of 92.2%, and that is a real number that goes in their column. ^[22]

Call the schools a draw and move on, because at this level the county grade is not what decides your kid’s classroom. The address does, and the address list is sheet A-12.

SECOND, SATURDAYS, AND THIS ONE DOES NOT SPLIT

DINOSAUR WORLD Plant City · ~10 minutes Around two hundred life-size dinosaurs in a pine wood, a fossil dig and a splash pad. It is in our zip code. For a five-year-old this may be the most persuasive fact in this entire document.	BUSCH GARDENS Tampa · ~35 minutes 335 acres, more than 12,000 animals, and a roller coaster for every stage of his life from now until he is too cool to go with you.
ZOOTAMPA & THE FLORIDA AQUARIUM Tampa · ~40 minutes A downtown zoo with a rooftop splash pad and an aquarium with touch tanks. Both are on the city pass with MOSI and the Glazer Children’s Museum.	CLEARWATER MARINE AQUARIUM Clearwater · ~1 hour Rescue and rehabilitation, on the water, on the way to the beach on sheet A-09.
ADVENTURE ISLAND & MOSI Tampa · ~35 minutes A water park for July and a hundred hands-on exhibits for the afternoons when July wins.	JACKSONVILLE’S ANSWER In fairness Jacksonville Zoo and Gardens is genuinely excellent, with more than 2,000 animals, giraffe feeding and a splash park, and MOSH is a good little science museum. That is most of the list.

THIRD, ORLANDO, WHICH IS THE WHOLE ARGUMENT IN ONE BAR



Forty-five minutes does not sound decisive until you price an annual pass. At eighty minutes Disney and Universal are an ordinary Saturday you decide on at breakfast. At over two hours they are a trip you plan, book and pack for, and a family does that three times, not thirty.

AND FOR THE TWO OF YOU, ONCE HE IS ASLEEP

Three pro teams, not one

Amalie Arena

The Straz Center

Tampa Theatre, 1926

Ybor City on a Friday

Gasparilla in January

The Dalí, an hour away

Armature Works

Their slide 7 gave you a backyard and beach days, and it was right to. We have the backyard and we have warmer water. We also have a dinosaur park in the zip code and Disney at breakfast-decision distance.

ACT THREE

THE WORK

Three careers restart the day you sign. The only question is how big a city they restart in.

7TH AVENUE, YBOR CITY · ERIC STATZER · CC BY-SA 4.0

YOU ARE NOT MOVING ONE CAREER. YOU ARE MOVING THREE.

Diego needs a firm. Naty rebuilds an ABA caseload from nothing. And the embroidery and printing business needs a market. That is the true price of this move, and I want to say plainly that it is the same price in either city.

So the only honest question left is which city gives you more to rebuild into. That question has a number attached to it.

3,040,000

TAMPA BAY
METRO POPULATION

1,360,000

JACKSONVILLE
METRO POPULATION

2.2x

MORE PEOPLE TO
REBUILD INTO

Tampa Bay is not slightly bigger. It holds 1.68 million more people than metro Jacksonville, which is roughly another whole Jacksonville and then some. ^[13]

FOR NATY, AND THIS ONE IS SPECIFIC

ABA is not work you can do from a laptop, and hours worked and hours billed are not the same number. A caseload is a geography. Her clients sit ten to twelve minutes from the front door right now, and that is not luck. That is the entire reason the schedule works.

The good news first, and it holds either way. The BCBA credential comes from the Behavior Analyst Certification Board and it is national. Florida does not run its own separate licence for behavior analysts, so she can cross the state on a Monday and still be certified on Tuesday. Neither move costs her the credential. ^[15]

An honest one next. Both cities are hiring. The job boards show comparable numbers of open BCBA roles in Tampa and in Jacksonville, and I am not going to dress that up into something it is not. Employment is not the differentiator here.

The differentiator is how far apart the children live.

Students in the county school district

THE POOL THAT SCHOOL-BASED REFERRALS AND CONTRACTS COME OUT OF



SCALE RUNS 0 TO 226,000 STUDENTS. HILLSBOROUGH IS ONE OF THE FEW LARGE DISTRICTS IN THE COUNTRY STILL GROWING. [16]

Then there is the driving, which is the part that decides whether the job is bearable. Jacksonville's city limits enclose 747 square miles of land, because the city and the county merged into one government in 1968. Tampa's enclose 114. [17]

That figure flatters my argument and I will say so, since counties are the fairer unit and Hillsborough County is not small either. But the practical version survives the caveat. A caseload described as "in Jacksonville" can be spread across that entire footprint, and every mile between two children is a mile nobody pays her for.

Around us the shape is the opposite. Brandon, Riverview, Valrico, FishHawk, Lithia, Seffner and Dover run straight into one another in a continuous belt of young families, and all of it sits inside twenty-five minutes of Plant City. That is the terrain where a ten-minute radius gets rebuilt.

FOR THE BUSINESS

Embroidery and 3D printing are demand businesses. They need crowds, teams, events, schools and small manufacturers within driving range, and this comparison is not close either.

THE STRAWBERRY FESTIVAL

573,299 guests · 2026

Eleven days, in Plant City, ten minutes from our house. The best-attended festival in Florida, and it happens in the town I am telling you to move to. [14]

GASPARILLA

~300,000 · every January

A pirate invasion the size of a mid-sized city, and every krewe, boat and bar in it wants something with a logo on it. [14]

THREE PRO TEAMS, NOT ONE

Bucs · Lightning · Rays

Plus the Rowdies. Jacksonville has the Jaguars. Youth leagues, booster clubs and bar merch follow the teams, and there are three times as many of them here.

CONVENTIONS AND CORPORATE

Downtown · year-round

The Tampa Convention Center, Amalie Arena and the Water Street district next door run events continuously. Badges, uniforms, giveaways and prototypes all have to come from somewhere.

Slide 5 leads with \$1.23 billion, Jacksonville's five-year capital improvement plan. That is a line in a municipal budget. It is not a project, it is a projection, and you have been in this business long enough to know the difference.

Here is what is under construction in Tampa Bay right now, by name.

WATER STREET TAMPA

Phase Two · under way

Roughly a \$3 billion district. Phase Two extends it across six new blocks, with an entertainment district and a 3,500-seat music venue unveiled in May 2026.

GASWORX

15 blocks · delivering 2026-27

Stitches Ybor City to downtown and Channelside. The Stevedore opens this year, the signature office tower completes later in 2026, a 28,000 sf marketplace lands in early 2027.

TAMPA GENERAL HOSPITAL

Expansion · active

Major healthcare work on a constrained island site. The kind of program that keeps a firm fed for years.

MIDTOWN TAMPA

Phase Two

Second phase of the mixed-use district between downtown and Westshore.

WESTSHORE MARINA DISTRICT

Build-out

Waterfront residential and mixed-use, still filling in.

BRANDON & WESLEY CHAPEL

Suburban corridors

Heavy multifamily and mixed-use volume. Unglamorous, continuous, and it pays.

All of it verifiable, all of it named, all of it hiring. ^[10]



Three careers restarting at once is a lot to ask of a city. Ask it of the bigger one.

SIX ANSWERS, AND NONE OF THEM ARE A CONDO.

Slide 6 gives you four flavors of Jacksonville, and it is a good slide.

Here are ours, weighted the way you would actually weight them: a yard, a decent school, and a drive that does not ruin the day.

PLANT CITY

≈ \$343,765

Where we are. Actual downtown, brick streets, strawberry fields, and the closest thing to Jacksonville's price with none of Jacksonville's distance. Twenty minutes from Brandon, forty from downtown Tampa.

BRANDON

≈ \$356,875

The practical middle. Everything is fifteen minutes away, including most of the Colombian food on sheet A-08.

RIVERVIEW / FISHHAWK

Newer builds

Master-planned, family-heavy, the kind of place where a five-year-old ends up with eleven friends on the same street.

LUTZ

≈ \$491,899

The premium suburb. Bigger lots, older oaks, strong schools, and a straight shot down the Veterans to the airport.

SEMINOLE HEIGHTS

If you want fabric

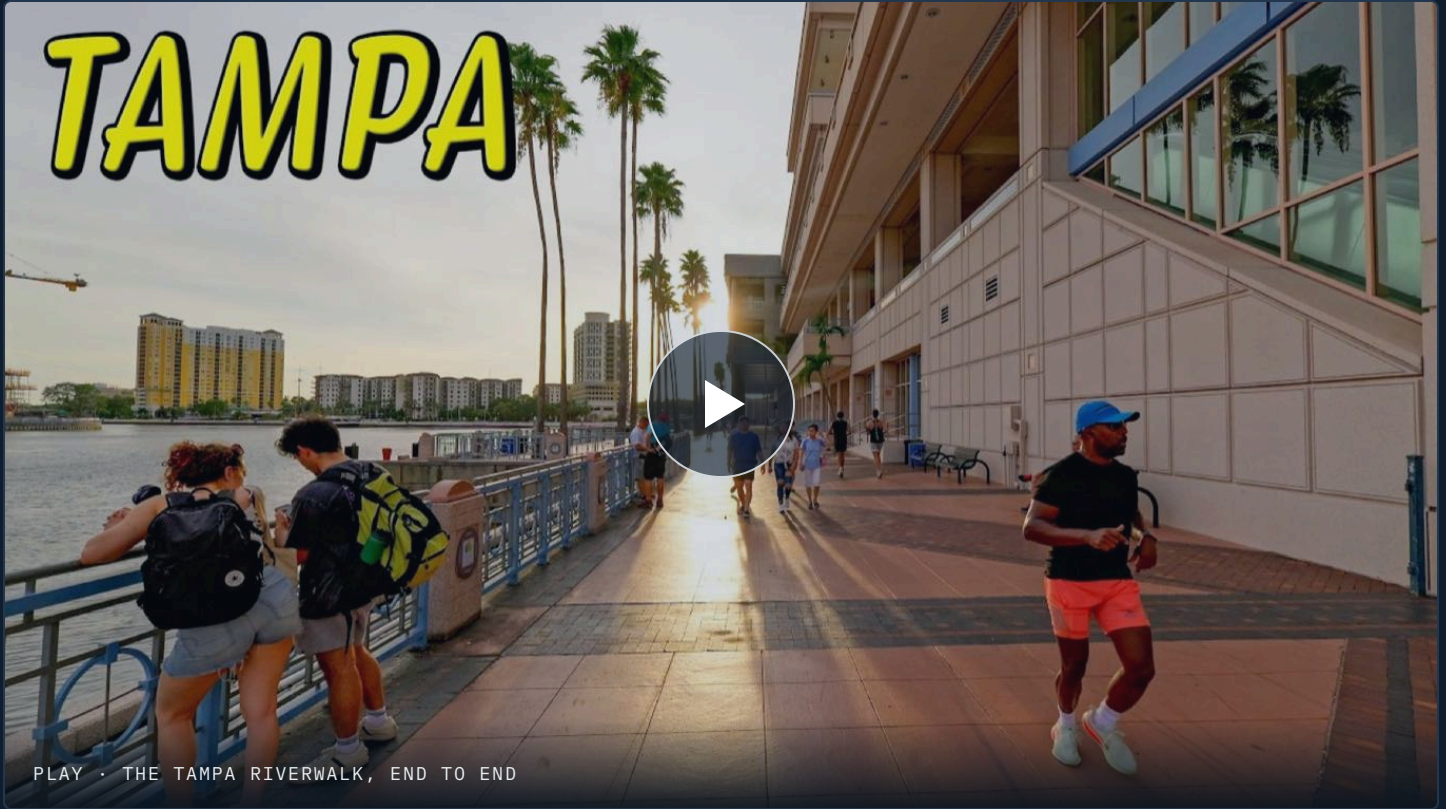
Bungalows, front porches, walkable blocks, an actual restaurant scene. Riverside and Avondale have nothing on it, and it is fifteen minutes from downtown.

YBOR CITY

For the nerd in you

A national historic landmark district built by Cuban and Spanish and Italian cigar workers, now being sewn back into downtown by Gasworx. Bring a camera.

TAMPA



And St. Petersburg exists and is lovely and I am deliberately not pitching it, because you two want a yard and a garage, not a walk-up near a pier.

BOTH CITIES ARE GETTING SAFER. ONE IS STARTING FURTHER BACK.

I want to be careful here, because this is the argument people overplay, and Jacksonville’s trend is genuinely good news.

74	17	-31%
MURDERS IN JACKSONVILLE, 2025	HOMICIDES IN TAMPA, 2025	TAMPA CRIME RATE, 2025 VS 2024

Jacksonville’s murder count fell below one hundred in 2024 for the first time since 2011, and it fell again in 2025. That is real progress by people working hard at it, and it deserves to be said out loud. ^[11]

It is also a count that started above one hundred for thirteen consecutive years. Tampa is a smaller city, so compare rates rather than counts if you want to be rigorous; Tampa’s violent crime rate sits marginally below the national average. Jacksonville’s sits well above it.

Neither city is a war zone and nobody should pretend otherwise. But this sheet was not in the deck, and it belongs in the decision.

ACT FOUR

THE VERDICT

Five things Jacksonville does better, the storm question answered straight, and the scorecard.

TAMPA THEATRE · MATTHEWHOOBIN · CC BY-SA 4.0

WHERE JACKSONVILLE ACTUALLY BEATS US.

Slide 11 conceded Miami's wins, and that concession is exactly why the rest of that deck reads as honest. Same rules here. These are real and I am not going to soften them. Sheet A-05 already handed Jacksonville two more.

IT IS CHEAPER. FULL STOP.

About \$48,000 less on a typical house and \$653 less a month to run a family. That is a vacation and a car payment every year. If your budget is the binding constraint, Jacksonville wins and you should go.

IT GRADUATES MORE OF ITS KIDS.

Duval's class of 2025 hit a 94.3% comprehensive graduation rate against Hillsborough's 90.9%, and beat the state average doing it. We have the better district grade; they have the better outcome at the end of it. Both belong in the decision. ^[22]

LESS TRAFFIC, MORE ROOM.

Jacksonville is the largest city by land area in the contiguous United States, and all that space buys lighter roads. Tampa Bay's commutes are genuinely worse and this one is not close.

THE ATLANTIC HAS WAVES.

If Diego ever wants to surf, or the kid does at fourteen, the Gulf will disappoint you roughly three hundred days a year.

ST. AUGUSTINE IS FORTY-FIVE MINUTES AWAY.

The oldest continuously occupied European settlement in the country, on a Saturday, for an architect. That is a genuinely great thing and we do not have an equivalent.

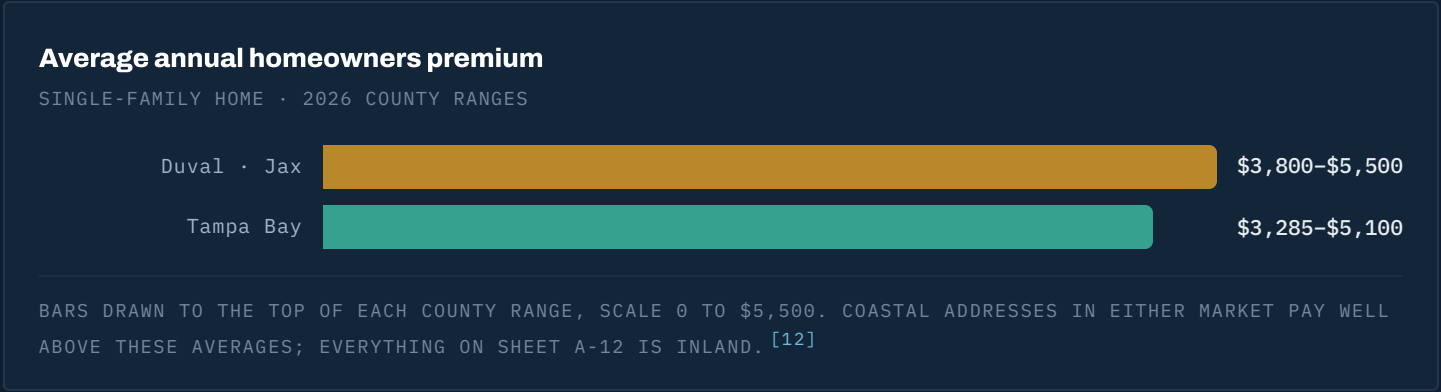
SOMEONE WHO LOVES YOU IS ALREADY THERE.

That is the last line of slide 12 and it is the best line in the deck. It counts. It counted for us too, once, and it is the only item on this list I cannot answer with a number.

You are going to raise 2024, and you should. Helene drove record surge into Tampa Bay that September, and Milton came ashore weeks later with a one-in-a-thousand-year rainfall over parts of the bay. That was real, it was frightening, and I am not going to wave it off.

Here is the context the coverage left out. Milton made landfall at Siesta Key, south of the bay, and it was the first hurricane to strike the Tampa Bay region in more than a century. The last direct hit on Tampa Bay by a major hurricane was 1921, near Tarpon Springs. One hundred and three years between them. ^[12]

And the people who price this risk for a living have already run the comparison you are about to run.



Jacksonville is not the cheaper insurance market. It is the more expensive one. Plant City sits thirty miles from open water and the premiums reflect it.

THE SCORECARD

“And your friend is already here.”

WE LIVED IN JACKSONVILLE. THEN WE MOVED HERE.

That is the whole close and I am not going to dress it up.

That deck argues from a brochure, and it argues well. We are arguing from a lease, a mortgage, a moving truck and a decision we made with our own money about where to raise our own kid. We ran the experiment. We had the house, and the beach forty minutes away, and every reason to believe it would be great.

You are about to restart two careers and a business in the same month. That is a hard year no matter where the truck stops. Do it once, and do it in the city that gives you the most to restart into, ninety minutes closer to every person you are related to.

Then we packed it up and drove two hundred miles southwest, and we have not spent one evening since wondering whether we got that wrong.

Everything on these seventeen sheets is a number you can check. This last part is the only thing I am asking you to take on faith, and it is the part I am most sure about.

THE ACTUAL OFFER

Come for a weekend. Not a tour, a weekend. Fly into Tampa, four hours from Bogotá whenever family comes, and stay with us in Plant City.

Saturday we do Ybor and downtown, and Diego can decide for himself whether there is work here. Sunday morning we take the kids to the Gulf, where the water is flat and warm and comes up to their chests a hundred feet out. Sunday lunch is at Los 3 Parces in Brandon, and I am going to let the name of that restaurant do the closing argument for me.

And if you come in early March, come during the Strawberry Festival, walk the grounds, and count the booths selling shirts. Then tell me there is nothing here for the two of you.

Then drive down to Miami on Sunday evening. It is four hours. You will be home for dinner, which is the entire point.

And if we are wrong, you will have had a free weekend at the beach and the pleasure of telling us so. Worst case, parce, is not that bad.

EVERY NUMBER, CHECKED 5 SEPTEMBER 2026.

Slide 13 was called “the receipts” and it was a good slide. Here are ours. Where I use the Jacksonville deck’s figures I have kept its sources, so you can hold both documents open at once.

- 01 Redfin, Jacksonville housing market, three months ending July 2026: median sale price \$309,845. *The deck’s source, the deck’s figure, accepted.*
- 02 Redfin, Miami housing market, three months ending July 2026: median sale price \$649,675. *The deck’s source, the deck’s figure, accepted.*
- 03 Livingcost.org, Jacksonville versus Tampa, updated 21 June 2026: family of four \$5,144 versus \$5,797 per month; median after-tax salary \$3,945 versus \$4,463. The Miami family figure of \$7,364 is the deck’s own, from the same tool.
livingcost.org/cost/jacksonville/tampa
- 04 Zillow Home Value Index, 2026: Miami \$581,864; Lutz \$491,899; Brandon \$356,875; Plant City \$343,765; Jacksonville \$295,910. zillow.com/home-values
- 05 Tampa International Airport and Avianca: nonstop TPA–BOG launched 30 March 2025 on the A320neo, roughly four hours, daily from October 2025, about twenty weekly flights as of September 2026. news.tampaairport.com
- 06 Jacksonville International Airport international service and route targets, Jacksonville Today, 3 April 2026; Jacksonville Aviation Authority via the Campbell-Hill route study: Dublin, Frankfurt, London, Paris, Reykjavík. jaxtoday.org
- 07 Driving distances and times: Jacksonville–Miami 345 mi, roughly 5 to 6 hours on I-95 depending on traffic; Jacksonville–Atlanta 346 mi; Tampa–Miami 280 mi, about 3h55m; Tampa–Orlando about 1h30; Tampa–Sarasota under an hour. Travelmath, Trippy and Lazytrips road-distance calculators.
- 08 Colombian population: roughly 85,000 across the Tampa Bay and greater Orlando metros, second-largest US concentration after Miami; Florida holds about 30% of the US Colombian diaspora. Migration Policy Institute and Latina Republic.
migrationpolicy.org
- 09 February water temperature: Clearwater Beach about 63°F; Jacksonville Beach about 58.8°F. NOAA-derived buoy and satellite averages via seatemperature.info and surf-forecast.com.
- 10 Tampa Bay project pipeline 2026: Water Street Phase Two, Gasworx, Midtown Phase Two, Tampa General expansion, Westshore Marina District. Tampa Bay Business & Wealth, December 2025; Water Street Tampa project progress; Davron 2026 pipeline report.
- 11 Homicides: Jacksonville 74 in 2025, below 100 in 2024 for the first time since 2011; Tampa 17 in 2025 with the overall crime rate down 31% year over year. City reporting compiled via jaxcrimdefense.com and city-data.com.

- 12 Insurance and storms: Hillsborough/Pinellas/Pasco homeowners premiums roughly \$3,285–\$5,100 a year against Duval County’s \$3,800–\$5,500. Hurricane Helene, September 2024, \$13.9B in damage and record Tampa Bay surge. Hurricane Milton, October 2024, made landfall near Siesta Key, south of Tampa Bay, with one-in-a-thousand-year rainfall over parts of the bay. The last direct hit on Tampa Bay by a major hurricane was the Tarpon Springs storm of 25 October 1921, 103 years earlier. GreatFlorida county rate tables; NOAA National Weather Service Tampa Bay; NOAA National Hurricane Center tropical cyclone reports. weather.gov/tbw/hurricane1921
- 13 Metro population, 2025: Tampa–St. Petersburg–Clearwater 3,040,000; Jacksonville 1,360,000. Macrotrends metro series from United Nations World Urbanization Prospects and US Census data.
- 14 Event attendance: Florida Strawberry Festival, Plant City, 573,299 guests over the 2026 event, reported by the festival as a record and the best-attended festival in Florida; Gasparilla Pirate Festival, Tampa, attendance around 300,000. flstrawberryfestival.com
- 15 Behavior analyst credentialing: the BCBA certification is issued nationally by the Behavior Analyst Certification Board. Florida is among the states without a separate state licence for behavior analysts and defers credentialing to the BACB, so certification carries across state and county lines. BACB and Florida licensure guides via appliedbehavioranalysis.edu.org and abadegree.org.
- 16 School enrolment: Hillsborough County Public Schools roughly 226,000 students, seventh-largest district in the United States and one of the few large systems still growing; Duval County Public Schools roughly 128,000 students, about twenty-second nationally and sixth in Florida. National Center for Education Statistics district data and district reporting.
- 17 Land area: Jacksonville 747.26 sq mi of land within city limits, the largest of any city in the contiguous United States, a result of the 1968 city–county consolidation; Tampa 114.0 sq mi. US Census Bureau city profiles.
- 18 Median household income, 2024: Hillsborough County \$79,540; Duval County \$71,277. US Census American Community Survey via USAFacts county profiles.
- 19 Growth: Lightcast projected the Jacksonville metro to grow 11% between 2023 and 2028, faster than any other major Florida metro, the state or the country, reported by JAXUSA. BEBR medium-series county projections via Plan Hillsborough: Hillsborough County 1,520,529 in 2020 to 1,981,900 by 2050; the eight-county Tampa Bay region 5,087,431 to 6,507,900. planhillsborough.org
- 20 Property tax: Duval County total millage about 17.86 against Hillsborough County about 15.73 for 2025; median annual bills \$2,820 and \$3,758 respectively. County millage tables via Ownwell and county property appraiser data.
- 21 Hospitals: US News & World Report 2026–27 Best Hospitals. Mayo Clinic Florida, Jacksonville, entered the national Honor Roll of 20 hospitals. Tampa General ranked first regionally for Tampa–St. Petersburg; Moffitt Cancer Center ranked second in Florida for cancer. wusf.org
- 22 Schools: Hillsborough County Public Schools earned an A district grade from the Florida Department of Education in 2026, its first in more than a decade, with a 2024–25 graduation rate of 90.9%. Duval County Public Schools holds a B district grade; its class of 2025 comprehensive graduation rate including charters was 94.3%, up from 90.9%, with traditional high schools at 97.6%. Florida’s statewide rate was 92.2% in 2025. District and Florida DOE reporting via hillsboroughschools.org, duvalschools.org and WUSF.

Attractions and drive times: Busch Gardens Tampa Bay, 335 acres and more than 12,000 animals; Dinosaur World, Plant City, around 200 life-size sculptures; ZooTampa, the Florida Aquarium, MOSI, the Glazer Children’s Museum and Clearwater Marine Aquarium, bundled on the Tampa Bay CityPASS; Jacksonville Zoo and Gardens, more than 2,000 animals, and MOSH. Tampa to Orlando about 1h20 on I-4; Jacksonville to Orlando about 2h05 on I-95. Visit Tampa Bay, Visit Jacksonville and Travelmath.

Where the two documents disagree on a number, distrust mine first, because I am the one with something to gain. Every figure above is linked or nameable so you can check me. Please check me.

Drawing set issued 5 September 2026 in response to “Miami → Jacksonville, Parce” (13 sheets, 4 September 2026). Prepared without the knowledge or consent of its author, who is a good friend, built a genuinely good case, and is wrong about exactly one thing.